

OF HIGH STAKES AND MIXED FORTUNES

At the Inter-State Championships, athletes were chasing not just medals, but a **spot at the Worlds** in Tokyo next month.

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Numbers told the real story at the 64th National Inter-State Senior Athletics Championships in Chennai, with every second, metre and ranking point shaping the fortunes of Indian athletes.

The domestic meet, held from August 20-24, was the last opportunity for Indian athletes to seal their spots at next month's World Championships (September 13-21) in Tokyo. There were two ways to do it: first, by meeting the entry standard for the showpiece event — clocking a certain time on the track, throwing or jumping a particular distance, or clearing the bar at a set height. Or second, by taking the complicated route of the World Rankings — checking the current standings and then calculating the required performance to gain enough points and secure a quota.

Neeraj Chopra (men's javelin throw), steeplechasers Parul Chaudhary and Avinash Sable (who is unlikely to compete at the Worlds due to injury), Gulveer Singh (men's 5000m),



and triple jumper Praveen Chithravel were the only automatic Indian qualifiers before the Inter-State meet. After five days in Chennai, there were no additions to this list.

Those whose rankings were already high enough to qualify for Tokyo played it safe and avoided peaking too soon, while those on the borderline were left to wait anxiously for the final list to be released by World Athletics on August 27.

Javelin throwers aplenty

For the second World Championships in a row, India looks set to have solid representation in a field of 36 male javelin throwers. Sachin Yadav (22nd in World Rankings) and Yash Vir Singh (30th) were likely to join Neeraj, who had already booked his spot via a wildcard reserved for the defending champion, even before the meet in Chennai.

However, Rohit Yadav (**above**) threw his name into the hat as well, producing a personal best of 83.65m to pip Asian Championships silver medallist Sachin (83.20m) for the gold. Rohit, the 24-year-old from Uttar Pradesh, made his Worlds debut in 2022